

Indian troops of Lieutenant Colonel Sawai Bhawani Singh's 10 PARA (Cdo) are pictured at Chachro. This unit was ordered to carry out a series of raids on Pakistani positions across the international border with the aim of assisting Indian Army operations and weakening the Pakistani line of communications in the Barmer sector. Of these, the raid on Chachro, more than 50km inside Pakistan, was the most significant and successful conducted by the Indian Army on enemy territory. Lieutenant Colonel Singh's battalion infiltrated on 5 December 1971 in two separate columns, reached their rendezvous and established a commando base 6km from Chachro, late on 6 December. After a brief confirmatory manoeuvre, the raid was launched at 0400hrs on 7 December. The battalion captured Chachro by first light, killing 17 Pakistani rangers and capturing a further 12. The post and the prisoners were handed over to 20 RAJPUT, which had linked up by then. This was the first long-distance raid across desert terrain undertaken by the Indian Army and became a benchmark for future operations of a similar nature. (ADGPI/Public Domain)

The Punjab region saw India's I Corps mount a major offensive in the Shakargarh sector, between the Basantar and Ravi rivers. On 5 December, I Corps made a double thrust from the north and east. The northern thrust between the Basantar and Bein rivers was conducted by 39 and 54 Infantry divisions and 16 (Independent) Armoured Brigade. Faced with minefields covered by tanks and anti-tank weapons, 39 Infantry Division made little progress; 54 Infantry Division established a bridgehead across the Basantar on 16 December, defending it against repeated Pakistani counter-attacks. By the time the ceasefire came into effect, 54 Infantry Division had penetrated 21km inside Pakistan. The eastern thrust was implemented by 36 Infantry Division; tasked with advancing across the Ravi and capturing Nainakot and Narkot, the division reached the Bein on 12 December, but could not make further progress.